Story: Influence Without Authority (Spotfire to Tableau, Moderna)

Practice date: 2026-10-21. Prompt: "Tell me about a time you drove a consequential technical or org decision that you had no authority to mandate."

The story in Shridhar's words (facts)

At Moderna, business reporting ran on two platforms Shridhar did not own: Spotfire, used for regulated reports, and Tableau, used for non-regulated reports. Spotfire licenses cost 50 to 60 percent more than Tableau because of specialized features for the regulated environment. His team built reports on top of both platforms. The platforms belonged to someone else.

He pulled the usage data and found that about 80 percent of the reports running on Spotfire were non-regulated work that Tableau could handle. Moving that usage would save roughly $50K per year in license costs, recurring. Nobody had asked him to do this.

Actions:

- Built a usage dashboard first: which reports are actively used, which are not, user login frequency. Data before persuasion.
- Reached out to customers one by one to understand why they used Spotfire versus Tableau.
- Worked with customers to rebuild sample reports in Tableau, showed the output, explained the rationale.
- Ran training sessions for the users.
- Staffed it himself: one of his engineers, 100 percent, for one quarter (roughly $70K of his own team's capacity).

Resistance: users feared what they would lose in the move (features they relied on), and they lacked the time and technical bandwidth on their end to learn a new tool. It was a priority problem, not stubbornness.

The user-side gain: on Tableau, non-regulated work developed faster, with quicker experimentation, because it skipped the heavier regulated workflow. Users gained speed, not just the company a saving.

Outcome: about 60 percent of the reports moved by the end of the quarter. The last roughly 20 percent of owners would not commit the time required for training, and Shridhar chose not to force them. The math: $70K one time against $50K a year recurring, with maintenance costs the same on both platforms. Year one was a wash; from year two onward the $50K a year is money no longer spent.

What went well in the mock

- The mechanism is textbook influence and all of it is real: data before persuasion, his own resources spent on someone else's platform problem (skin in the game), and a genuine user-side trade (speed) rather than a company-side saving dressed up as one.
- The honest partial win reads as credible: 60 percent moved, holdouts named, and a deliberate choice not to force them. A clean 100 percent claim would have sounded invented.
- The ROI defense is sound once stated: one-time cost versus recurring saving, maintenance parity, payback from year two.

What went wrong in the mock

- The ROI logic only appeared under probing. In the first telling the figures were tangled (50 to 60 percent, $50K, one engineer, a quarter), and an interviewer doing the math live would have concluded the trade lost money. The one-time-versus-recurring framing belongs in the main answer, before anyone asks.
- The resistance beat trailed off in the first telling, which made the win sound frictionless. The probed version - fear of losing features, no time to learn - is more believable and sets up the fix (rebuilt reports, training).
- Story selection caution: $50K a year is small at Senior Director scale. For EM-level loops this story works as told. For Director loops, lead with the mechanism and expect a "why this example" push, or reach for a bigger-stakes adoption story.

The ideal answer (~2.5 minutes spoken)

"At Moderna, business reporting ran on two platforms I did not own: Spotfire, which we used for regulated reports, and Tableau, for everything else. Spotfire licenses cost 50 to 60 percent more, because of specialized features built for the regulated environment. My team built reports on top of both. The platforms belonged to someone else.

I pulled the usage data and found the waste. About 80 percent of the reports running on Spotfire were non-regulated work that Tableau could handle, and moving that usage would save roughly 50,000 dollars a year in license costs, every year. Nobody had asked me to do this, and I had no authority over either platform or over the users. So I staffed it myself: one of my engineers, full time for a quarter, roughly 70,000 dollars of our own capacity. Seventy thousand once, against fifty thousand a year, with maintenance costs equal on both sides. Year one was a wash. Every year after that is money we simply stopped spending.

We started with data, not persuasion. I built a dashboard of which reports were actually used, how often, and by whom, so every conversation was about real usage rather than opinions. Then I went customer by customer. The resistance was never really about the tool. People feared losing features they relied on, and they did not have time to learn a new one. So we removed both excuses: we rebuilt their key reports in Tableau ourselves, showed them the output side by side, and ran training sessions. And the trade was real for them. On Tableau, non-regulated work moved faster, with quicker experimentation, because it skipped the heavier regulated workflow.

By the end of the quarter, 60 percent of the reports had moved. The last 20 percent of owners would not commit the training time, and I chose not to force them, because influence runs out where a mandate would begin, and I did not have a mandate.

What I took from it: influence without authority is mostly removing reasons to say no. The data made the waste undeniable, the rebuilt reports made the move safe, and the users moved because the new tool was faster for the work they actually did."

Likely follow-ups, with the honest answers

- "Why was this your problem to solve?" - "It was not, formally. My team paid the cost of the waste in the reports we maintained, and I could see the usage data nobody else had pulled together. Influence usually starts with volunteering for the unowned problem."
- "Does the math actually work? An engineer-quarter for 50K a year?" - "Year one, honestly, no - we spent roughly 70,000 dollars to save 50,000. From year two the saving recurs and the cost does not. Maintenance is the same on both platforms, so nothing eats the saving later."
- "Why not just escalate and get a mandate for the last 20 percent?" - "Because the holdouts were not wrong about their constraint - they had no time. A mandate would have moved reports and broken trust with the exact users I need for the next change. The door stays open instead."